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AN EVALUATION OF ENVIRONMENTAL DISCLOSURES MADE IN CORPORATE ANNUAL REPORTS*

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Abstract

This paper evaluates the quality and accuracy of environmental disclosures made in corporate annual reports. Annual report disclosures made by 26 firms in environmentally sensitive industries are examined. An indexing procedure is used to measure the contents of the disclosures, and the relationship between the disclosure contents and the firms' environmental performance is tested. The study provides a detailed measure of environmental disclosure contents. Results indicate that corporate environmental disclosures are incomplete and are not related to the firms' actual environmental performance.

Environmental performance is a major issue facing U.S. corporations. Societal demands for a cleaner environment accompanied by extensive environmental legislation have forced firms to undertake and actively participate in extensive pollution control programs. Corporate involvement in environmentally related activities has precipitated both the need and demand for a measurement and reporting system to account for corporate environmental performance. To date, however, no such system has been agreed upon or uniformly adopted. Thus, the current state of environmental reporting by corporations remains principally voluntary. The purpose of this paper is to examine the quality of voluntary environmental disclosures made by corporations in their annual reports. First the contents of these disclosures are analyzed utilizing an indexing procedure. Next the relationship between a firm's environmental disclosure contents and the firm's actual environmental performance is examined.

The first section of the paper provides an overview of the corporate environmental reporting issue including related research. Next the sample of firms used and the methodology employed are discussed. Results of both the indexing procedure and the statistical analyses are then presented. The final section of the paper discusses conclusions of the research and their implications on the environmental reporting issues.

ENVIRONMENTAL REPORTING BACKGROUND

The accounting profession and the SEC have recognized the importance of the environmental measurement and reporting issue. In 1973, the Study Group on the Objectives of Financial Statements proposed that one of the basic objectives of corporate reporting should be:

> to report on those activities of the enterprise affecting society which can be determined and described or measured and which are important to the role of the enterprise in its environment (1973, p. 54).

Research studies and committee reports of the major accounting associations addressed the environmental measurement and reporting issue either separately or as an integral part of corporate social accounting (AAA, 1971–1975, 1976, 1978; NAA, 1974, 1976, 1977; AICPA, 1972, 1976). The SEC presently requires registrants to disclose:

> material effects that compliance with federal, state, and local provisions regulating the discharge of materials into the environment, or otherwise relating to the protection of the environment, may have upon the capital expenditures, earnings and competitive position of the registrant. . .(1973).

and is currently considering proposals for more extensive environmental disclosure requirements.

In addition, numerous studies in the accounting literature have both advocated the need for environ-

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mental reporting and proposed detailed environmental measurement and reporting systems (examples include: Beams and Fertig, 1971; Dierkes and Preston, 1977; Estes, 1976; Council on Economic Priorities, 1975). These studies in conjunction with the professional research efforts and SEC requirements emphasize the extensive interest in and need for an environmental accounting system.

Voluntary response by corporations to the demands for environmental reporting has been extensive. In addition to SEC required disclosures made in footnotes to financial statements, the majority of Fortune 500 firms include environmental performance information in other sections of their annual reports. The number of firms making these environmental disclosures has increased steadily over the past eight years (Ernst and Whinney, 1978). However, the quality of both the required and voluntary corporate environmental disclosure has not been established.

Investigations into the accuracy and completeness of required environmental disclosures have been conducted by both the House Commerce Committee and the SEC (Business Week, 12 May, 1980). Discrepancies between reported environmental information in financial statements and EPA reports were the focus of these investigations.

Voluntary environmental disclosures have been widely criticized as being self-serving, inaccurate accounts of corporate environmental performance (Dierkes and Preston, 1977; Churchill, 1978; Nader, 1978). However, there has been little empirical evidence other than anecdotal, to support these accusations. Instead, previous research has focused on the usefulness of social and environmental disclosures to investors (Buzby and Falk, 1978, 1979; Longstreth and Rosenblook, 1973; Williams, 1980), or on the relationship between social disclosures and the firms' financial or market performance (Ingram, 1978; Balkaoui, 1980; Spicer, 1978). Results of these studies have been mixed, but most agree that social and in particular environmental information is desired and useful information for investment decisions. Further, there appears to exist a positive relationship between a firm's social disclosures and its market performance as well as between a firm's environmental and financial performance.

Previous attempts to evaluate the contents of voluntary environmental disclosures have been generally descriptive surveys. The annual social disclosure survey prepared by Ernst and Whinney is representative of these studies. Their survey gives a page count of social disclosures made in annual reports of the Fortune 500 companies including the social topics discussed and the amount of space devoted to each.

Research investigating the relationship between social performance and social disclosure has mixed results. Bowman and Haire (1976) concluded that the length of a firm's social disclosures was representative of the firm's social performance. Ingram and Frazier (1980) found only a weak association between a firm's social disclosures and its social performance. The present study expands on previous social diclosure research by first examining specific contents of corporate environmental disclosures and then by testing the accuracy of the environmental disclosures.

THE SAMPLE

A sample of 26 of the largest companies in the steel, oil, and pulp and paper industries was selected for the study. These industries are widely recognized as being among those with the greatest environmental problems and having the greatest expenditures on pollution control (EPA, 1978; McGraw-Hill, 1976; Council on Environmental Quality, 1977). Thus information on the environmental performance of firms within these industries has greater potential usefulness to investors and other corporate constituencies than information for firms in non-environmentally sensitive industries.

Specific companies were chosen from each of these industries based on the availability of external environmental performance measures compiled by the Council on Economic Priorities (CEP). Such measures of actual environmental performance were critical to this research as they provided a standard for evaluating the accuracy of the environmental disclosures. The CEP is the only credible source available for objective environmental performance measures of individual companies. (A list of the companies included in the sample is presented in Appendix A.)

The CEP is a non-profit organization dedicated to evaluating corporate social performance. In 1977, they published a *Pollution Audit* giving comparative environmental performance rankings for companies within each of the industries included in this study. The rankings were based on the Council's previous in-depth research studies of firms' pollution control performance.

Annual reports were obtained for each of the

companies in the sample for the years corresponding to the CEPs evaluations of environmental performance. These years included both 1972 and 1976 for the steel industry, 1974 for the oil industry, and 1972 for the pulp and paper industry.

The annual report was selected as the source for corporate environmental disclosures. It is widely recognized as the principal means for corporate communication of activities and intentions to shareholders and is the primary source of environmental reporting by corporations. The annual report has been the source for virtually all previous corporate disclosure research (Barrett, 1976; Buzby, 1974; Cerf, 1961; Singhvi and Desai, 1971) and the source for all the social disclosure research previously discussed.

METHODOLOGY

An indexing procedure similar to the ones used by Buzby (1974) and Singhvi and Desai (1971) for evaluations of corporate disclosure in annual reports was constructed to evaluate the contents of the annual report environmental disclosures. The purpose of this procedure was first to objectively measure the information contained in the disclosures and second to provide a systematic numerical basis for comparing companies' disclosures with external environmental performance evaluations.

Items of information to be included in the index were selected through a review of the environmental reporting literature (Dierkes and Preston, 1977; Estes, 1976; CEP, 1975). These sources provided proposed formats for environmental reports incuding items of information considered essential for complete environmental disclosure. A list of these essential categories and items of information was compiled. From this list, 18 items of information were selected for inclusion in the index. Certain items were excluded if they were not reported in any of the environmental disclosures.

A rating sheet was developed to measure the extent of disclosure of the 18 index items. The items on the rating sheet were classified into four categories. Category one represented items directly related to economic factors. Category two represented items relating to environmental litigation. Category three included pollution abatement items. Category four represented other environmentally related items which did not fall into any of the previous categories. A list of the 18 items by category is contained in Appendix B.

Rating of the disclosures was based on the presence or absence and the degree of specificity of each of the information items. A score of three was assigned to an item if it was present in the disclosure and was described in monetary or quantitative terms. This was the highest score possible for an item since monetary or quantitative measures are recommended as the preferred disclosure form (CEP, 1975). A score of two was assigned to an item if it was presented in the disclosure with company specific information in non-quantitative terms. One was assigned to items mentioned only in general terms. A zero was assigned if the item was not present in the disclosure.

Since any rating procedure is subject to a certain degree of arbitrariness, a rating sheet was completed independently by the author and two other coders. Any disagreements were thoroughly examined and reconciled by careful re-evaluation of the disclosure in question.

The rating sheets were then tabulated. Industry averages for each item of disclosure were compiled. Six index scores were computed for each company for use in the statistical analysis. These included an index score for each of the four categories, an overall disclosure index score and a line count score.

RESULTS

Indexes of disclosure

Results of the rating of items of information are presented by industry in Table 1. The total environmental disclosure index scores and the line count scores for each company are presented by industry in Table 2.

Several observations about the state of voluntary corporate environmental disclosure can be made from an examination of the index ratings. First there was a distinct lack of specificity in disclosed information. Although many companies are reporting information on a majority of the items, the numerous zero and one scores in Table 1 indicate this reporting is vague and incomplete. The literature advocating corporate environmental disclosure emphasizes the necessity of reporting specific numerical measures for each of the items. However the results show that for most items such numerical measures (as indicated by a score of 3) are not being voluntarily reported. For example, past and current expenditures on pollution control equipment and

TABLE 1. Environmental disclosure ratings: steel industry, 1972

Categories and items of information	Number of firms reporting	Average industry score	Number of firms with score = 3	Number of firms with score = 2	Number of firms with score = 1
Economic factors					
Past and current expenditures for pollution control equipment and facilities	6	2.57	5	0	0
Past and current operating costs of pollution control equipment and facilities	2	0.71	1	1	0
Future estimates of expenditures for pollution control equipment and facilities	4	1.43	3	0	1
Future estimates of operating costs for pollution control equipment and facilities	0	0	0	0	0
Financing for pollution control equipment or facilities	3	1.29	3	0	0
Litigation					
Present litigation	3	0.71	0	2	1
Potential litigation	1	0.14	0	0	1
Pollution abatement					
Air emission information	6	1.57	1	3	2
Water discharge information	6	1.57	1	3	2
Solid waste disposal information	2	0.57	0	2	0
Control, installations, facilities or processes described	6	2.00	2	4	0
Compliance status of facilities	3	0.71	0	2	1
Other environmentally related information					
Discussion of regulations and requirements	3	0.86	0	3	0
Environmental policies or company concern for the environment	4	0.57	0	0	4
Conservation of natural resources	0	0	0	0	0
Awards for environmental protection	0	0	0	0	0
Recycling	1	0.29	0	1	0
Departments or offices for pollution control	1	0.29	0	1	0

facilities was the item most frequently reported in monetary terms, yet costs of operating the equipment were only included in seven of the 33 annual reports examined. Also the majority of firms did not include quantitative measures of air emissions or water discharges and only three firms disclosed the number of facilities in compliance with environmental regulations.

Arguments are often made that the cost of reporting this additional specific information exceed possible benefits. However much of the information missing from these environmental disclosures is available to the companies at little or no additional cost. The compliance status of facilities, air emission and water discharge information, and descriptions of the adequacy of facilities are examples of items companies already report to the EPA. Costs of facilities and equipment as well as their operating costs should be determinable from accounting records. Yet instead of reporting this information the companies reported very general environmental information in often lengthy disclosures.

Length of the environmental disclosures is presented in Table 2. For the steel industry the length ranged from 12 to 61 sentences, but the index scores for the same companies only increased from 9 to 25. Thus even in the longest disclosure the index score is

TABLE 1a. Environmental disclosure ratings: steel industry, 1976

Categories and items of information	Number of firms reporting	Average industry score	Number of firms with score = 3	Number of firms with score = 2	Number of firms with score = 1
Economic factors					
Past and current expenditures for pollution control equipment and facilities	6	2.29	5	0	1
Past and current operating costs of pollution control equipment and facilities	4	1.57	3	1	0
Future estimates of expenditures for pollution control equipment and facilities	5	1.86	4	0	1
Future estimates of operating costs for pollution control equipment and facilities	2	0.43	0	1	1
Financing for pollution control equipment or facilities	3	1.29	3	0	0
Litigation					
Present litigation	4	1.29	2	1	1
Potential litigation	0	0	0	0	0
Pollution abatement					
Air emission information	6	1.57	2	1	3
Water discharge information	5	1.29	1	4	0
Solid waste disposal information	3	1.00	1	2	0
Control, installations, facilities or processes described	7	2.29	3	3	1
Compliance status of facilities	6	1.29	0	3	3
Other environmentally related information					
Discussion of regulations and requirements	6	1.29	1	1	4
Environmental policies or company concern for the environment	4	0.71	0	1	3
Conservation of natural resources	0	0	0	0	0
Awards for environmental protection	0	0	0	0	0
Recycling	0	0	0	0	0
Departments or offices for pollution control	1	0.29	0	1	0

TABLE 1b. Environmental disclosure ratings: oil industry, 1974

Categories and items of information	Number of firms reporting	Average industry score	Number of firms with score = 3	Number of firms with score = 2	Number of firms with score = 1
Economic factors					
Past and current expenditures for pollution control equipment and facilities	7	2.38	6	0	1
Past and current operating costs of pollution control equipment and facilities	1	0.38	1	0	0
Future estimates of expenditures for pollution control equipment and facilities	1	0.38	1	0	0
Future estimates of operating costs for pollution control equipment and facilities	0	0	0	0	0
Financing for pollution control equipment or facilities	0	0	0	0	0
Litigation					
Present litigation	0	0	0	0	0
Potential litigation	0	0	0	0	0
Pollution abatement					
Air emission information	8	1.25	0	2	6
Water discharge information	6	1.00	0	2	4
Solid waste disposal information	1	0.13	0	0	1
Control, installations, facilities or processes described	7	1.75	0	7	0
Compliance status of facilities	1	0.25	0	1	0
Other environmentally related information					
Discussion of regulations and requirements	4	0.63	0	1	3
Environmental policies or company concern for the environment	4	0.50	0	0	4
Conservation of natural resources	3	0.50	0	1	2
Awards for environmental protection	1	0.13	0	1	0
Recycling	0	0	0	0	0
Departments or offices for pollution control	0	0	0	0	0

TABLE 1c. Environmental disclosure ratings: pulp and paper industry, 1972

Categories and items of information	Number of firms reporting	Average industry score	Number of firms with score = 3	Number of firms with score = 2	Number of firms with score = 1
Economic factors					
Past and current expenditures for pollution control equipment and facilities	10	2.36	8	0	2
Past and current operating costs of pollution control equipment and facilities	2	0.55	2	0	0
Future estimates of expenditures for pollution control equipment and facilities	7	1.73	6	0	1
Future estimates of operating costs for pollution control equipment and facilities	1	0.09	0	0	1
Financing for pollution control equipment or facilities	4	0.91	3	0	1
Litigation					
Present litigation	2	0.27	0	1	1
Potential litigation	0	0	0	0	0
Pollution abatement					
Air emission information	10	1.55	1	5	4
Water discharge information	10	1.82	4	2	4
Solid waste disposal information	8	1.00	0	3	5
Control, installations, facilities or processes described	9	1.55	2	4	3
Compliance status of facilities	6	1.00	2	1	3
Other environmentally related information					
Discussion of regulations and requirements	6	0.73	0	2	4
Environmental policies or company concern for the environment	10	1.27	0	4	6
Conservation of natural resources	9	1.73	2	6	1
Awards for environmental protection	3	0.55	0	3	0
Recycling	6	1.27	3	2	1
Departments or offices for pollution control	2	0.27	0	1	1

TABLE 2. Environmental disclosure index scores

Steel Industry, 1972		Steel Industry, 1976	
Total environmental disclosure index	Line count index	Total environmental disclosure index	Line count index
13	16	20	28
9	12	15	15
21	29	27	37
18	14	10	14
10	25	14	22
18	24	25	61
17	28	19	29

Oil Industry, 1974		Pulp and Paper Industry, 1972	
Total environmental disclosure index	Line count index	Total environmental disclosure index	Line count index
8	7	29	44
15	31	12	12
6	4	17	14
13	8	20	27
3	9	25	29
15	16	30	29
6	12	12	14
9	12	6	24
		19	33
		28	67
		7	25

less than half of the possible score of 54. This pattern is consistent for firms in the other industries as well. The conclusion that follows is that the length of the environmental disclosure is not representative of its quality.

Comparing between industries, the oil companies' environmental disclosures are consistently shorter and less complete than disclosures made by companies in the other industries. This finding may indicate the existence of industry-wide disclosure patterns for environmental reporting.

The above results support the contention that voluntary environmental reports are inconsistent across firms, incomplete, and often provide only general accounts of environmental performance by corporations. Basic items which are considered necessary by the CEP and others in environmental reports were not adequately disclosed by companies in this sample. Thus the usefulness of environmental reports contained within the corporate annual report for inter-company performance comparisons is questionable.

In the next section an analysis of the relationship between the environmental reports and the firms' actual environmental performance is presented.

Comparison of disclosure indices and CEP rankings

To determine the relationship between the index measures of corporate environmental disclosures and the companies' environmental performance the following null hypothesis of no association was statistically tested:

Ho: There is no significant association between the CEP environmental performance rankings and the environmental disclosure index rankings.

The six disclosure indexes compiled from the rating scores were used to form six sets of within industry company rankings. This produced a set of company index rankings for each of the categories of items in Appendix B, a total environmental disclosure index ranking of companies, and a environmental disclosure line count ranking of companies for each industry. Each of the index rankings was then tested for degree of association with the CEP environmental performance rankings using Spearman's Rank Correlation Coefficient. Table 3 presents the results of this analysis.

TABLE 3. Spearman's rank order correlation coefficients*

	Total environmental disclosure index	Economic disclosure index	Litigation disclosure index	Pollution emission information disclosure index	Other environmental disclosure	Line count
Steel, 1972						
CEP rankings	−0.05406	−0.25944	−0.35857	0.37062	0.38188	0.03571
	(0.9084)	(0.5742)	(0.4296)	(0.4131)	(0.3979)	(0.9394)
Steel, 1976						
CEP rankings	0.03571	−0.37435	−0.4909	0.52254	0.23905	0.07143
	(0.9394)	(0.4081)	(0.3121)	(0.2289)	(0.6057)	(0.8790)
Oil						
CEP rankings	−0.26508	−0.01277	0.0000	−0.48196	−0.12123	−0.43115
	(0.5258)	(0.9761)	(1.0000)	(0.2265)	(0.7749)	(0.2862)
Pulp and Paper						
CEP rankings	0.30524	0.22372	−0.05394	0.20691	−0.12965	0.10959
	(0.3614)	(0.0260)	(0.8749)	(0.8749)	(0.7040)	(0.7484)

*The level of significance associated with each correlation coefficient is provided in brackets below the coefficient.

The results indicate that the null hypothesis of no association between the six environmental disclosure content rankings and the CEP environmental performance rankings could not be rejected with the exception of the economic index rankings in the pulp and paper industry. Many of the correlation coefficients, although not statistically significant, have negative signs indicating that a possible inverse relationship between a firm's environmental performance and its annual report environmental disclosure may exist. Further observations about the specific findings can be made.

The fact that the index score rankings computed for pollution emission information contained in the disclosures were not related to the actual performance rankings is especially interesting. The CEP rankings were based primarily on pollution emission facts. A lack of correlation between the pollution abatement index, which is comprised of emission facts disclosed in the annual reports, and the CEP indicates that the reporting of these facts was not related to the companies' actual environmental performance.

Again some industry reporting differences can be seen from this analysis. The significant positive association between the economic disclosure index ranking and the CEP ranking found in the pulp and paper industry indicates that in this industry more complete expenditure reporting may have been made by companies with better environmental performance. However, this was not the case in the other industries, and the negative direction of this coefficient in the other industries may imply the opposite conclusion.

The lack of significant association between the line count rankings and the CEP rankings shows that longer environmental disclosures do not represent better environmental performance as has been previously suggested (Bowman and Haire, 1976). In fact there is no relationship between disclosure length and environmental performance based on this analysis. This finding also provides some insight into previous research utilizing a measure of the amount of social disclosure in annual reports for market association tests. The results of such studies are only demonstrating the relationship between social disclosures and market performance and not between social performance and market performance.

Overall, there appears to be no relationship between the measurable information companies disclose about environmental performance in their annual reports and their actual environmental performance, based on this sample of firms. Analysis of the completeness, length, and items of information included in voluntary environmental disclosures is not a representative measure of actual environmental performance, and may in fact misrepresent a firm's performance compared to other firms in the same industry.

SUMMARY

This study has attempted to measure and evaluate voluntary environmental disclosures made by companies in their annual reports in order to provide preliminary evidence on the relationships between objective measures of a firm's environmental disclosure and the firm's actual environmental performance. An indexing procedure was used to measure the extent of disclosure of 18 environmental information items in 26 companies' annual reports. The index measurements were then compared to actual environmental performance measures compiled by the CEP.

The findings indicated that the voluntary environmental disclosures were incomplete, providing inadequate disclosure for most of the environmental performance items included in the index. Further it was demonstrated that no relationship existed between the measured contents of the firms' environmental disclosures and the firms' environmental performance.

This evidence provided in this paper suggests further research is necessary to determine the quality of corporate social disclosures. This is especially important if the social disclosures are utilized as surrogates for a firm's social performance in investment decisions and in market-related research.

APPENDIX A. SAMPLE COMPANIES

Oil Industry	Steel Industry	Pulp and Paper Industry
Amoco	Armco	American Can
Arco	Bethlehem	Continental Can
Exxon	Inland	Great Northern Nekoosa
Gulf	J & L	Hammermill Paper
Mobil	National	International Paper
Shell	Republic	Kimberly-Clark
Socal/Chevron	U.S. Steel	Owens-Illinois
Texaco		Scott Paper
		St. Regis Paper
		Union Camp
		Weyerhaeuser

APPENDIX B. INDEX CATEGORIES AND ITEMS OF INFORMATION

1. *Economic factors*
   Past and current expenditures for pollution control equipment and facilities.
   Past and current operating costs of pollution control equipment and facilities.
   Future estimates of expenditures for pollution control equipment and facilities.
   Future estimates of operating costs for pollution control equipment and facilities.
   Financing for pollution control equipment or facilities.
2. *Litigation*
   Present litigation.
   Potential litigation.
3. *Pollution abatement*
   Air emission information.
   Water discharge information.
   Solid waste disposal information.
   Control, installations, facilities or processes described.
   Compliance status of facilities.
4. *Other environmentally related information*
   Discussion of regulations and requirements.
   Environmental policies or company concern for the environment.
   Conservation of natural resources.
   Awards for environmental protection.
   Recycling.
   Departments or offices for pollution control.

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